

BUT SERIOUSLY...
AAP CM candidate Bhagwant Mann at a roadshow near Balachaur

face an uphill task. Anti-incumbency remains a factor. The Ramdassia sect that Channi belongs to commands only a fourth of the total 32 per cent Dalit vote and Channi has to work hard to win the confidence of his other Dalit brethren. The flip side is that a Dalit unification may not be to the liking of the powerful Jat Sikhs, who still tend to view them through the prism of the old landlord-serf relationship. So they may consolidate behind the Akali Dal. Channi is also seen as more of a leader of the Doaba belt than one native to Malwa proper, the region that has the maximum number of assembly seats (69) and where most of the Dalits reside. The Congress has allowed Channi to also contest from Bhadaur in Barnala district in Malwa to shore up votes among the Mazhabi Sikhs/ Valmikis, a Dalit segment often opposed to Ravidassia dominance. Another negative factor is that the fear of further rebellion has seen a nervous Congress nominate a majority of its sitting MLAs, even the non-performers, which could cost them at

AAM AADMI PARTY

Chief ministerial candidate
BHAGWANT MANN, 48
Alliance partner: None

STRENGTHS

- Party seen as the best alternative to the SAD and the Congress
- Its poll promises, including Rs 1,000 per month to all women, are a big draw
- Bhagwant Mann is popular, particularly in the Malwa region
- The party is pushing hard to win support among Dalits and Hindus

CHALLENGES

- Lack of pan-Punjab presence; the party is especially weak in the Doaba and Majha regions
- Mann's mercurial temperament and allegations of alcohol abuse do him no credit
- The party lacks organisational strength across the state
- About half its candidates are turncoats from other parties